missiles from Turkey. In actual fact, all those involved must have known what they were doing—making a secret swap without acknowledging it not only publicly but even privately.[11]

The conspirators were supposed to return to the ExCom session in an hour or so and discuss the options for the solution of the crisis while keeping Robert's mission secret from any interlocutors. The president had already decided on the trade. At that point, of course, few believed that the mission would succeed. After all, secret diplomatic deals were normally struck by allies or allies-to-be, not by adversaries on the verge of a major military conflict. The new atomic weapons turned both sides into hostages of possible nuclear annihilation. The two parties had to find some way of trusting each other. They had managed to do that in Berlin one year earlier. Maybe they would get lucky once again.

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ROBERT KENNEDY MET WITH ANATOLY DOBRYNIN IN HIS office at the Department of Justice soon after the president's secret gathering in the White House. "I told him first that we knew that work was continuing on the missile bases in Cuba and that in the last few days it had been expedited," wrote Robert Kennedy in *Thirteen Days*, recalling the message that he delivered to Dobrynin. "I said that in the last few hours we had learned that our reconnaissance planes flying over Cuba had been fired upon and that one of our U-2s had been shot down and the pilot killed. That for us was a most serious turn of events. President Kennedy did not want a military conflict. He had done everything possible to avoid a military engagement with Cuba and with the Soviet Union, but now they had forced our hand."[12]

In his own memoirs, Dobrynin recalled that Robert Kennedy had been much more explicit in speaking of the urgency of the situation. "The American military was demanding permission from the president to retaliate," Robert allegedly told the ambassador. In the report on the meeting that Dobrynin filed later that night, he expanded on Kennedy's explanation of the dangers posed by the new situation. "The USA